The urban transportation problem

The urban transportation problem is something that almost every one of us experiences. Particularly in cities like Bengaluru, just visiting three or four places in different parts of the city can consume a whole day. Apart from the waste of time for an individual, imagine the amount of productive time lost for so many in the city. It's immaterial whether you own a private vehicle or depend on the public transportation – productive working hours are unnecessarily lost.

Many government and private players are trying to solve the problem in their own way, and often, these efforts are not coordinated. For example, we may have a metro but many people won't use it for the simple reason that it doesn't provide an end-to-end solution. That is, if it takes more than a few minutes to walk to the metro station from your house, you may have to depend on other transportation methods and this complicates the problem. Though city buses are very convenient in terms of an 'end-to-end' solution, they consume too much time.

And then we have the problem of air pollution. Electric vehicles can solve this problem, but we have two critical problems–the limited range of the vehicle and the time needed for a commute.

In such a context, can we apply or use ideas from the FOSS movement to solve urban transportation problems? What would be the key activities? What contribution can we expect from the volunteers? How can the open source movement actually help in such a traditional industry involving automobiles and transportation?

Project Vidyut: A platform for electric vehicles

Project Vidyut is a not-for-profit initiative that aims to solve the transportation problem. It is greatly inspired by the ideals of the FOSS movement. Its focus is on electric vehicles. And there are two specific approaches:

1. Designing and building electric vehicles and improving key parameters like range and charge duration.
2. Designing 'intelligent' systems whereby we can use existing electric vehicle technology.

In the first approach, we'll have to design electric vehicles (whether two-wheeled or four-wheeled), do all the engineering analysis, and coordinate the efforts of different research/engineering teams to solve critical battery problems.

In the second approach, we will not try to improve the design of vehicles, but attempt to design a system that uses vehicles with existing technology. Basically, the idea is to build an 'intelligent' system that uses a combination of different modes of transportation, according to the situation, availability and cost. This will not be another system designed in isolation, but more like *stitching* things together in real-time.

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